

**India, UAE Ink Major  
Pacts On Energy, De-  
fence, AI; Abu Dhabi  
Commits \$5 Billion  
Investment**  
PG 3

**Unified Payments In-  
terface Accounted for  
Over 85% of Digital  
Transaction Volume  
in H2 2025, Says RBI**  
PG 5



**IITM**  
INSTITUTE OF INFORMATION  
TECHNOLOGY & MANAGEMENT

**BA JMC (HONS.)**  
2026-27 Admissions  
Through Entrance Exam  
CONTACT US: +91-7217872847  
www.iitmjanakpuri.com

Eminent Faculty  
Opportunity for interaction with Media & Film celebrities  
Cutting Edge Audio - Video Production studios  
State - of - the - art Apple IMac based Editing Lab  
Dedicated Graphic Designing lab  
100% Internship and Placement Assistance  
Multiple Entry and Exit System (MEES)

**BA JMC (HONS.)**  
Bachelor of Arts in Journalism and Mass Communication  
2026-27 Admissions Open  
Apply through Entrance Exam

CONTACT US: +91-7217872847  
www.iitmjanakpuri.com

New Delhi | Vol. 08 | May 2026 | Pages 08 | Price Rs. 5.00 | Bilingual | [www.iitmjanakpuri.com](http://www.iitmjanakpuri.com)

## Department of Computer Science Signs MoU with MONCERRA to Strengthen Industry-Academia Collaboration

IITM Bureau

In a significant step towards enhancing industry-academia collaboration and improving career opportunities for students, the Department of Computer Science at the Institute of Information Technology and Management (IITM) has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with MONCERRA on May 31, 2026. The partnership aims to bridge the gap between classroom learning and professional careers by providing students with greater exposure to industry practices and emerging technologies. The MoU marks the beginning of a strategic collaboration focused on creating meaningful learning opportunities for students through industry engagement, hands-on training, and professional skill development. Under the agreement, students will benefit from practical learning experiences, expert interactions, workshops, internships, and exposure to real-world technological challenges. Speaking on the occasion, representatives from IITM highlighted the importance of industry partnerships in preparing students for the rapidly evolving digital landscape. They noted that the collaboration with MONCERRA aligns with the institute's vision of nurturing professionals equipped with the knowledge, skills, and adaptability required in today's technology-driven world. The partnership is expected to facilitate knowledge exchange between academia and industry, enabling students to gain insights into current market trends, innovative technologies, and industry expectations. It will also help strengthen employability by providing opportunities for experiential learning and career-oriented training. Officials from MONCERRA expressed their enthusiasm for the collaboration and reaffirmed their commitment to supporting student development through mentorship, technical expertise, and industry-driven initiatives. They emphasized the importance of creating a workforce that is well-prepared to meet the demands of modern enterprises and digital transformation. With this collaboration, IITM continues to expand its network of industry partners and reinforce its commitment to academic excellence and professional growth. The MoU is expected to open new avenues for students, helping them successfully transition from classrooms to rewarding careers in the technology sector. The collaboration also reflects the growing importance of industry-academia partnerships in fostering innovation, entrepreneurship, and technological advancement. By creating a platform for continuous interaction between students, faculty members, and industry professionals, the initiative is expected to encourage research-driven learning and practical problem-solving skills. As organizations increasingly seek professionals with both technical expertise and industry exposure,



try-academia partnerships in fostering innovation, entrepreneurship, and technological advancement. By creating a platform for continuous interaction between students, faculty members, and industry professionals, the initiative is expected to encourage research-driven learning and practical problem-solving skills. As organizations increasingly seek professionals with both technical expertise and industry exposure,

## IITM NCC Cadets Shine at CATC-03 Camp 2026 with Outstanding Achievements

IITM Bureau

The NCC cadets of the Institute of Information Technology and Management (IITM), Janakpuri, successfully completed the Combined Annual Training Camp (CATC)-03 Camp 2026, held from April 22 to May 1, 2026. The camp provided cadets with an opportunity to enhance their leadership qualities, discipline, teamwork, and military training skills. Through their dedication, perseverance, and exemplary performance, the IITM cadets brought laurels to the institution and upheld the core NCC motto of "Unity and Discipline." Among the notable achievements, Senior Under Officer (SGT) Kaveesh Sharma emerged as the star performer of the camp by winning the prestigious Best Cadet Award. He also played a significant role in securing first place in the debate competition alongside Cadet Aditya Mukherjee. Demonstrating excellence in communication, leadership, and overall performance, Kaveesh was also entrusted with the responsibility of serving as the Squadron Commander during the camp. The IITM cadets excelled in various competitive events. Cadets Aditya Mukherjee and Ravi Kumar Jha secured first position in the Map Reading Competition, showcasing their navigation and fieldcraft skills. In sports events, Cadet Tanish Kumar Choudhary emerged as a winner in volleyball, while SGT Mohit and Corporal Jatin Siwach secured the Runner-Up position in Volleyball, reflecting the team's sporting excellence. The cadets also performed exceptionally well in camp management and area maintenance competitions. SGT Kaveesh Sharma, Cadet Shaurya Bharadwaj, Cadet Suraj Thakur, and Corporal Aditya Mishra secured the Runner-Up position in the Line Area Competition. Additionally, SGT Kaveesh Sharma and Corporal Aditya Mishra earned the Runner-Up position in the Flag Area Competition, demonstrating their commitment to maintaining high standards of discipline and presentation. Cadets were entrusted with important leadership responsibilities during the camp.

## Department of Commerce, IITM Organizes Seminar on NASSCOM Virtual Internship Program

IITM Bureau

The Department of Commerce at the Institute of Information Technology and Management (IITM) organized an informative seminar on the NASSCOM Virtual Internship Program on May 6, 2026, aimed at equipping students with industry-relevant skills and enhancing their career readiness. The session focused on helping students bridge the gap between academic learning and the practical demands of the professional world. The seminar provided valuable insights into the opportunities available through the NASSCOM Virtual Internship Program, which is designed to prepare students for the rapidly evolving job market. Participants learned about the importance of acquiring industry-ready skills, gaining hands-on experience through real-time projects, and developing competencies that align with current industry requirements. During the session, students were intro-



duced to various benefits offered under the internship program, including exposure to emerging technologies, mentorship from industry professionals, project-based learning, and certification opportunities. The discussion highlighted how such initiatives can enhance employability and help students build strong professional profiles before entering the workforce. The keynote speaker, Sankalp Madaan, shared valuable perspectives on industry trends and the growing demand for skilled professionals across sectors. He emphasized the importance of continuous learning, adaptability, and practical exposure in today's competitive employment landscape. His presentation encouraged students to take advantage of internship opportunities that offer real-world experience and industry engagement. Faculty members of the Department of Commerce noted that such industry-oriented programs play a crucial role in complementing classroom education. They reiterated the department's commitment to providing students with platforms that foster skill development, career awareness, and professional growth. The interactive session witnessed enthusiastic participation from students, who actively engaged in discussions and sought guidance on internship opportunities and career pathways. The seminar concluded with a vote of thanks to Mr. Sankalp Madaan for delivering an enriching and motivating session. The initiative reflects IITM's ongoing efforts to create future-ready professionals by combining academic excellence with practical industry exposure, enabling students to confidently transition from classrooms to successful ca-

reers. The seminar also underscored the growing significance of virtual internships in providing flexible and accessible learning opportunities for students across disciplines. By participating in structured internship programs, students can gain practical knowledge, improve problem-solving abilities, and develop professional competencies that are highly valued by employers. Such initiatives not only strengthen technical and managerial skills but also help students build confidence, expand their professional networks, and better understand workplace expectations. IITM continues to create meaningful opportunities that empower students to enhance their employability

## InternHunt 9.0 at IITM Connects Students with Exciting Internship Opportunities

IITM Bureau

Reinforcing its commitment to enhancing students' career prospects and industry exposure, InternWare - The Internship Cell of IITM successfully organized its flagship event, InternHunt 9.0 - The Internship Fair, on May 8, 2026. The event witnessed enthusiastic participation from students and recruiters, creating a vibrant platform for professional networking and career exploration. Held with the objective of bridging the gap between academia and industry, InternHunt 9.0 brought together aspiring students and reputed organizations under one roof. The fair provided participants with an opportunity to explore a wide range of internship openings, interact directly with recruiters, and gain valuable insights into industry expectations and workplace culture. The event was more than a conventional recruitment drive. It served as a dynamic forum where talent met opportunity, en-



abling students to discover new career paths and build meaningful professional connections. Through engaging conversations and one-on-one interactions, participants were able to showcase their skills, aspirations, and potential to prospective employers. The atmosphere throughout the event reflected enthusiasm, determination, and a shared commitment to growth. Students actively interacted with company representatives, sought guidance regarding career opportunities, and explored internships across diverse domains. Recruiters, on the other hand, were able to identify promising young talent and gain fresh perspectives from the next generation of professionals. Speaking about the significance of the event, members of InternWare highlighted that opportunities do not always arrive on their own; they often require initiative, persistence, and the courage to pursue them. InternHunt 9.0 embodied this spirit by encouraging students to step forward, engage with industry leaders, and take meaningful steps toward their professional goals. The success of InternHunt 9.0 reflects IITM's continuous efforts to foster employability, practical learning, and industry engagement among its students. The event not only opened doors to internship opportunities but also inspired participants to broaden their horizons and prepare themselves for future challenges. With another successful edition concluded, InternWare looks forward to creating even greater opportunities for students through future initiatives, strengthening the connection between academic learning and professional success. As the professional landscape continues to evolve, in-

ternship opportunities have become an essential component of career development, allowing students to apply classroom knowledge in real-world settings and gain valuable practical experience. InternHunt 9.0 successfully reinforced the importance of early industry engagement by connecting students with organizations that value innovation, talent, and fresh perspectives. The event not only facilitated recruitment opportunities but also helped participants develop confidence, communication skills, and a deeper understanding of industry requirements. IITM continues to empower students to become competent, industry-ready professionals capable of thriving in competitive global workforce.



## Cultural Diplomacy in Action: PM Modi Showcases India’s Heritage Through Handicrafts and Traditional Gifts for World Leaders

IITM Bureau

In Norway, PM Modi gifted handcrafted Indian artworks to members of the Norwegian leadership and royal family. Norwegian Prime Minister Jonas Gahr Støre received pressed orchid paintings and orchid paperweights made from flowers sourced from Sikkim. Crown Prince Haakon, Crown Prince of Norway was presented a Kalamkari painting featuring Sun and Moon motifs, while Queen Sonja of Norway received a Palm Leaf Pattachitra artwork from Odisha. At the India-Nordic Summit, PM Modi also presented gifts to the Prime Ministers of Finland, Iceland and Denmark. Finnish Prime

Minister Petteri Orpo was gifted a Kamal Talai Pichwai painting from Rajasthan, while Icelandic Prime Minister Kristrún Frostadóttir received a replica of the historic ice axe used by mountaineer Tenzing Norgay during the first successful Everest ascent. Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen was presented a Bidri silver work vase from the Deccan region. In Sweden, PM Modi gifted Crown Princess Victoria, Crown Princess of Sweden a copy of his book “Convenient Action: Continuity for Change.” Swedish Prime Minister Ulf Kristersson received a handcrafted Shantiniketan leather bag, works of Rabindranath Tagore, artisanal Loktak tea from Manipur and a traditional Ladakh Pashmina stole.



During the Netherlands leg of the visit, PM Modi presented Dutch King Willem-Alexander of the Netherlands with GI-tagged Blue Pottery from Rajasthan, while Queen Máxima of the Netherlands received Meenakari and Kundan earrings crafted in traditional Rajasthani style. Dutch Prime Minister Rob Jetten was gifted a Madhubani painting featuring a fish motif symbolising harmony and ecological balance. During his visit to Italy, PM Modi presented Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni with a traditional Muga silk stole and a Shirui Lily silk stole.

## ‘Khet Bachao Abhiyan’ Reaches 2.71 Crore People Across India To Promote Sustainable Farming

IITM Bureau

The Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) on May 22, 2026, reported significant outreach achievements under its nationwide ‘Khet Bachao Abhiyan’, a major initiative focused on promoting soil health, encouraging balanced fertilizer use, and advancing sustainable agricultural practices across the country. The campaign, being implemented under the Department of Agricultural Research and Education, has reached nearly 2.712 crore citizens through digital and media outreach initiatives, according to an official statement issued on Thursday. As part of the initiative,



12,979 awareness camps and seminars have been organized across the country so far, directly engaging around 7.17 lakh farmers on scientific nutrient management and sustainable farming practices. To strengthen capacity building, 3,145 training programmes were conducted with participation from more than 1.11 lakh people. In addition, 7,928 field demonstrations were organized to provide practical exposure on green manuring, bio-fertilizers and organic nutrient sources. The campaign also focused on grassroots participation through 4,916 Janpratinidhi Sammelans involving Panchayat representatives, Sarpanches and Zila Parishad members. Recognizing the role of agricultural input suppliers, the

campaign conducted 9,609 interaction sessions with fertilizer and input dealers to spread awareness about balanced fertilizer application and soil conservation. Farmer collectives were also involved extensively, with 8,383 farmer-members connected through Farmer Producer Organizations (FPOs), Self-Help Groups (SHGs) and Farmer Interest Groups (FIGs). For wider public visibility, banners, posters and hoardings were displayed at 53,616 locations across the country. The outreach effort was further amplified through 1,144 media broadcasts, including 944 radio talks and 200 television.

Union Agriculture and Farmers’ Welfare and Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Friday (May 22, 2026) directed officials to adopt a time-bound, result-oriented and technology-driven governance model to ensure that farmers, rural citizens and the poor receive government benefits without unnecessary delays or procedural hurdles. A day after Prime Minister Narendra Modi issued key governance directives during the Union Council of Ministers meeting, Shivraj Singh Chouhan chaired a high-level review meeting with senior officials from the Ministries of Agriculture and Farmers’ Welfare and Rural Development. During the meeting, the Union Minister said governance should be visible in the lives of people and not remain confined to official files. He stressed that farmers and ordinary citizens should not be forced to “run from pillar to post” either for grievance redressal or to access the benefits of government schemes. Referring to Prime Minister Modi’s governance mantra of “Reform, Perform, Transform and Inform,” Chouhan said reforms in administration and service delivery would bring happiness and prosperity to farmers and rural communities.

## Google and UNICEF Partner to Train Assam Teachers in AI-Enabled Classroom Learning, Says CM Sarma

IITM Bureau

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Sunday (May 24, 2026) said artificial intelligence (AI) is rapidly transforming every sector and asserted that the state cannot afford to miss opportunities emerging from the technological shift. In a post on X, the Chief Minister announced that tech giant Google, in collaboration with UNICEF, will implement the “AI Educator Series” in Assam to train teachers in the use of AI tools for classroom learning and improved pedagogy delivery. “AI is

fast reshaping every avenue and we cannot miss the bus on this rapid transformation,” Sarma said in his post. According to the Chief Minister, the initiative aims to equip teachers with the skills required to effectively integrate AI-based tools into the education system and make classroom learning more interactive and efficient. Officials said the programme is expected to focus on helping educators understand emerging AI technologies, digital learning tools and modern teaching practices to improve classroom engagement and learning outcomes. The

initiative is also likely to support teachers in adapting to evolving educational requirements in an increasingly technology-driven environment. Sarma has repeatedly emphasised the importance of digital transformation and technology adoption in governance, education and skill development in Assam. In recent years, the state government has launched several initiatives to strengthen digital infrastructure, expand smart classroom facilities and promote innovation-driven education models. Education experts believe AI-enabled teaching

methods can help teachers personalise lessons, monitor student performance more effectively and improve access to quality educational resources. The collaboration between Google and UNICEF is expected to further strengthen Assam’s efforts to modernize its education system and prepare students and teachers for future technological challenges. The announcement comes at a time when governments and educational institutions across the country are increasingly exploring the use of AI tools to improve teaching methods

## IRCTC Unveils Revamped Golden Chariot Luxury Train For 2026-27

IITM Bureau

Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation has launched the upgraded version of the Golden Chariot for the 2026-27 tourist seasons on May 21, 2026, introducing refreshed interiors, and modern amenities and curated travel experiences across South India. The luxury train, operated by the tourism arm of Indian Railways under the Ministry of Railways, has been redesigned to combine heritage-inspired travel with contemporary comfort. According to the company, the revamped train features upgraded upholstery, polished wooden interiors, refreshed cabins with plush linens, premium bath amenities, Smart TVs and onboard Wi-Fi streaming services. The train has also been equipped with modern safety systems including CCTV surveillance and advanced fire-alarm mechanisms. The Golden Chariot can accommodate up to 80 guests across 40 cabins, including 13 double-bed cabins, 26 twin-bed cabins and one specially designed cabin for differently abled passengers. Dining facilities on-board include two signature restaurants Ruchi and Nalapaka serving Indian and international cuisine, while Madira lounge bar offers a curated beverage experience. Passengers will also have access to the Argya Spa and Fitness Centre, which offers Ayurvedic therapies, wellness treatments and fitness facilities. For the 2026-27 season, Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation has announced three curated itineraries covering heritage, wildlife and coastal destinations across southern India. The flagship “Pride of Karnataka” itinerary covers Bengaluru, Bandipur, Mysuru, Halebidu, Chikkamagaluru, Hampi and Goa over six days. The “Jewels of South” route includes Bengaluru, Mysuru, Kanchipuram, Mahabalipuram, Thanjavur, Chettinad, Cochin and Chertala.

## Farmers Should Not Run From Pillar To Post For Benefits: Shivraj Singh Chouhan

IITM Bureau

Union Agriculture and Farmers’ Welfare and Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Friday (May 22, 2026) directed officials to adopt a time-bound, result-oriented and technology-driven governance model to ensure that farmers, rural citizens and the poor receive government benefits without unnecessary delays or procedural hurdles. A day after Prime Minister Narendra Modi issued key governance directives during the Union Council of Ministers meeting, Shivraj Singh Chouhan chaired a high-level review meeting with senior officials from the Ministries of Agriculture and Farmers’ Welfare and Rural Development. During the meeting, the Union Minister said governance should be visible in the lives of people and not remain confined to official files. He stressed that farmers and ordinary citizens should not be forced to “run from pillar to post” either for grievance redressal or to access the benefits of government schemes. Referring to Prime Minister Modi’s governance mantra of “Reform, Perform, Transform and Inform,” Chouhan said reforms in administration and service delivery would bring happiness and prosperity to farmers and rural communities.

## West Bengal CM Meets PM Modi In New Delhi, Seeks Centre’s Backing For Welfare, Development Push

IITM Bureau

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Friday (May 22, 2026) met Prime Minister Narendra Modi during his first visit to Delhi after taking office earlier this month. He said the Centre had assured full support for the BJP-led government’s development and welfare agenda in the state. In a post on X after the meeting, Adhikari said PM Modi reaffirmed the Centre’s commitment to West Bengal’s progress and reiterated the vision of “Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas”. “This marks my first

official meeting with the Hon’ble PM since assuming the responsibility of serving the people of West Bengal as the Chief Minister. I extend my deepest gratitude to the Hon’ble PM for his warm wishes and, above all, for his unwavering commitment to the progress of our state,” Adhikari said. The Chief Minister said the Prime Minister assured all possible assistance from the Centre to help the state government implement its promised development initiatives and accelerate economic growth, industrial revival and

## IRCTC Unveils Revamped Golden Chariot Luxury Train For 2026-27

IITM Bureau

plush linens, premium bath amenities, Smart TVs and onboard Wi-Fi streaming services. The train has also been equipped with modern safety systems including CCTV surveillance and advanced fire-alarm mechanisms. The Golden Chariot can accommodate up to 80 guests across 40 cabins, including 13 double-bed cabins, 26 twin-bed cabins and one specially designed cabin for differently abled passengers. Dining facilities on-board include two signature restaurants Ruchi and Nalapaka serving Indian and international cuisine, while Madira lounge bar offers a curated beverage experience. Passengers will also have access to the Argya Spa and Fitness Centre, which offers Ayurvedic therapies, wellness treatments and fitness facilities. For the 2026-27 season, Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation has announced three curated itineraries covering heritage, wildlife and coastal destinations across southern India. The flagship “Pride of Karnataka” itinerary covers Bengaluru, Bandipur, Mysuru, Halebidu, Chikkamagaluru, Hampi and Goa over six days. The “Jewels of South” route includes Bengaluru, Mysuru, Kanchipuram, Mahabalipuram, Thanjavur, Chettinad, Cochin and Chertala.



ties. The Minister instructed departments including Agriculture, Rural Development, Land Resources and the ICAR to strengthen grievance redressal mechanisms and make them more accountable and responsive. He directed the formation of dedicated teams of at least 10 officers each in both ministries to conduct daily reviews of complaints, citizen representations, public grievances and issues raised through various portals. Chouhan

stressed that grievance redressal should not remain limited to disposal on paper and officials must verify whether actual relief has reached beneficiaries on the ground. He noted that in some cases, discrepancies had emerged between official records and field realities during direct interactions with beneficiaries. The Minister announced that grievance redressal systems would now be reviewed every month to monitor outcomes.

## West Bengal CM Meets PM Modi In New Delhi, Seeks Centre’s Backing For Welfare, Development Push



youth empowerment. The West Bengal CM also said he was confident that, with the support of the Union government and the mandate of the people, West Bengal would enter a phase of “double-engine growth”, transparent governance and holistic development. During the Assembly election campaign, Prime Minister Modi had repeatedly

said that the vision of a “Vikshit India” could not be realised without a “Vikshit Bengal”. The BJP secured a sweeping victory in the 2026 West Bengal Assembly elections, winning 207 of the 294 seats, while the Trinamool Congress was reduced to 80 seats. Adhikari later took oath as the state’s ninth chief minister.



## Strategic Partnership Deepens as India and UAE Ink Major Pacts Across Energy, Defence and AI Sectors; Abu Dhabi Pledges \$5 Billion

IITM Bureau

India and the United Arab Emirates on Friday (May 15, 2026) signed a series of agreements across energy, defence, maritime infrastructure and emerging technologies during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Abu Dhabi, with the Gulf nation announcing investments worth \$5 billion in India. According to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), the two sides reviewed the full spectrum of bilateral ties and welcomed the expansion of cooperation across sectors including energy, trade, investment, defence, security, fintech, infrastructure, education and culture. They also underlined the



continued success of the India-UAE Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), which has significantly boosted bilateral trade. During the discussions, the UAE announced investments worth USD 5 billion in India through multiple entities. The investments include USD 3 billion by Emirates New Petroleum Reserves Development Bank Limited and Abu Dhabi National Oil Compa-

ny (ADNOC) signed a strategic collaboration agreement to enhance the UAE's participation in India's strategic petroleum reserves and explore the creation of strategic gas reserves in the country. Indian Oil Corporation and ADNOC also finalised a long-term LPG supply arrangement. In the defence sector, the two countries signed a Framework for Strategic Defence Partnership aimed at deepening industrial collaboration and expanding cooperation in advanced technologies, maritime security, cyber defence, training, secure communications and information exchange. India and the UAE also expanded maritime

cooperation through an MoU between Cochin Shipyard Limited and Drydocks World, Dubai for establishing a ship repair cluster at Vadinar under India's Maritime Development Fund Scheme. A separate tripartite agreement involving Cochin Shipyard, Drydocks World and the Centre of Excellence in Maritime & Shipbuilding was signed for skill development in ship repair and shipbuilding. Further, the two sides announced a partnership between C-DAC and UAE-based G42 to establish an 8 Exaflop Super Compute Cluster to support India's AI Mission and advanced computing capabilities.

## At Least 24 Killed In Pakistan Train Blast Claimed By Separatist Militants

IITM Bureau

A bomb blast hit a shuttle train carrying Pakistani security personnel and their families in the southwestern province of Balochistan on Sunday (May 24, 2026), officials said, in the latest major attack claimed by separatist militants. The explosion killed at least 24 people and injured around 70, according to three provincial government and security officials, who spoke on the condition of anonymity as they are not authorized to speak to the media. The attack was the latest in a series of strikes on trains, security forces and infrastructure



in the mineral-rich province that borders Iran and Afghanistan, where Pakistan has launched counterinsurgency operations after some of the deadliest violence in years. The separatist militant group Baloch Liberation Army, or BLA, said in a statement to media that it carried out the attack and described it as a suicide bombing. Reuters could not independently verify the claim. The shuttle train was carrying passengers from Quetta's cantonment area to connect with the Jaffar Express long-distance train when the blast struck near a railway track in the provincial capital, Pakistan's railways ministry said in a statement. The explosion

derailed the engine and three coaches, while two coaches overturned, the ministry said, adding that security forces had cordoned off the area and rescue operations were under way. A security official said an explosives-laden vehicle hit one of the train's bogies in a residential area, and that some of those killed were residents of a nearby apartment building. Images from the scene showed burnt-out vehicles, damaged residential buildings, twisted metal and debris scattered near the railway track, with smoke rising from the wreckage. Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif condemned

what he called a "heinous bomb explosion" in a post on social media website X. He expressed condolences for the victims' families and said the nation stood with the people of Balochistan. In March 2025, BLA militants hijacked the Jaffar Express train, taking hundreds hostage before a military operation ended the day-long standoff. The military said 21 hostages, four troops and all 33 attackers were killed. Earlier this year, Pakistani forces killed 145 militants in a 40-hour operation after coordinated attacks across Balochistan left nearly 50 people dead, provincial officials said.

## Trump Says New Iran Deal Nears Completion Amid Ongoing Negotiations

IITM Bureau

The United States and Iran are moving closer to a possible peace agreement, with negotiators agreeing on the broad principles of a deal, CBS News reported on Sunday (May 24, 2026), citing a senior Trump administration official. According to the report, Iran has, in principle, agreed to a deal that would include the disposal of highly enriched uranium, while both sides have broadly committed to the framework of the agreement. The development comes after US President Donald Trump said on Sunday that any future agreement with Tehran would differ sharply from



the nuclear deal negotiated during the presidency of Barack Obama. Criticizing the Obama administration, Trump alleged that the earlier agreement provided Iran with substantial financial relief while leaving open a pathway to nuclear weapons development. He described his proposed deal as the "exact opposite" and said negotiations were still underway. "If I make a deal with

Iran, it will be a good and proper one, not like the one made by Obama, which gave Iran massive amounts of cash, and a clear and open path to a nuclear weapon. Our deal is the exact opposite, but nobody has seen it, or knows what it is. It isn't even fully negotiated yet," Trump said on Truth Social. Trump also said that Washington would not "rush into a deal" with

Tehran to resolve the crisis in West Asia. He asserted that the US "blockade" on Iranian ports would remain in "full force and effect" until a formal agreement is reached, signed by both sides. Meanwhile, a senior adviser to Iran's Supreme Leader said on Sunday that Tehran's nuclear energy programme remains peaceful and is under continuous monitoring by the International Atomic Energy Agency. Mohsen Rezaei also warned that Iran would break any naval blockade imposed by the United States on its vessels and ports, and could withdraw from the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT)

if Washington resumes attacks against the Islamic Republic. Rezaei, a former commander of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), said Iran remained prepared for any possible aggression. "Our fingers are on the trigger," he said, referring to the current security situation in the region. He also said the IRGC Navy monitors and identifies vessels passing through the strategically important Strait of Hormuz to prevent military aggression and maintain security in the Persian Gulf. The coming weeks will be crucial in determining whether the negotiations result in a formal agreement or renewed tensions.

## BRICS Members Reaffirm Anti-Terror Cooperation At CTWG Meetings In New Delhi

IITM Bureau

India hosted the 11th Annual BRICS Counter Terrorism Working Group (CTWG) Plenary and Sub Groups' Meetings in New Delhi on May 21-22. The member nations reaffirmed their commitment to strengthening cooperation against terrorism and condemned the April 2025 terror attack in Pahalgam, Jammu and Kashmir, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Saturday (May 23, 2026).

The meetings, held under India's BRICS Chairship, also marked 10 years of the establishment of the BRICS Counter Terrorism Working Group. Senior counter-terrorism

officials from all 10 BRICS member countries participated in the discussions, which covered the full spectrum of counter-terrorism cooperation and emerging security challenges. Ambassador Sibi George, Secretary (West) in the Ministry of External Affairs, delivered the keynote address during the inaugural session. He stressed the need for collective and united efforts among BRICS nations to tackle the global menace of terrorism and called for making the CTWG more resilient, constructive, innovative, inclusive and result-oriented. George also thanked BRICS member countries for

expressing solidarity with India following the "heinous terrorist attack" in Pahalgam on April 22, 2025, and reiterated India's policy of zero tolerance towards terrorism. The meetings were chaired by Dr. Vinod Bhaude, Joint Secretary (Counter Terrorism) in the Ministry of External Affairs. According to the MEA, BRICS member countries condemned the Pahalgam terror attack as well as other terrorist attacks targeting member nations and reaffirmed their resolve to further enhance cooperation in counter-terrorism efforts. The plenary session was preceded by meetings of five thematic sub-groups.

## US Says Green Card Applicants On Temporary Visas Must Leave Country To Apply

IITM Bureau

The US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) have issued a new policy memo tightening rules for foreign nationals on temporary visas seeking permanent residency in the United States. Under the revised policy, individuals seeking a Green Card while staying in the US on non-immigrant visas such as student, tourist or temporary work visas will generally be required to return to their home country and complete the immigration process through US consulates abroad. According to the USCIS statement issued on May 21, 2026, ad-

justment of status within the United States will now be treated as an "extraordinary form of relief" and granted only in limited cases. The agency said the policy aligns with long-standing immigration law and court decisions that expect non-immigrant visa holders to pursue immigrant visa processing through consular channels managed by the United States Department of State. The USCIS stated that officers would assess requests on a case-by-case basis while considering all relevant circumstances before allowing adjustment of status from within

the country. USCIS spokesperson Zach Kahler said the move restores the "original intent of the law" and reinforces the expectation that temporary visa holders should leave the US once their authorised stay ends. He said individuals seeking permanent residency should ordinarily apply from their home country unless exceptional circumstances justify otherwise. According to Kahler, the revised process is intended to reduce misuse of the immigration system and discourage individuals from remaining in the country illegally after being denied residency.

## Israel, Lebanon Extend Ceasefire By 45 Days As

### Washington Talks Conclude

IITM Bureau

Israel and Lebanon agreed to a 45-day extension of a ceasefire that has tamped down the conflict between Israel and Iran-backed Hezbollah in southern Lebanon, as two days of talks facilitated by Washington concluded on Friday (May 15, 2026) with an agreement to hold further meetings in the coming weeks. "The April 16 cessation of hostilities will be extended by 45 days to enable further progress," State Department spokesperson Tommy Pigott said on X, adding that the talks aimed at settling decades of conflict between the two countries were

"highly productive." The ceasefire was set to expire on Sunday. The Lebanese and Israeli delegations issued positive statements about the talks, their third meeting since Israel intensified air attacks on Lebanon after Hezbollah fired missiles at Israel on March 2, three days into the U.S.-Israeli war with Iran. Israel's bombing campaign and ground invasion into Lebanon's south displaced some 1.2 million people, before U.S. President Donald Trump announced a ceasefire last month following initial talks between the two countries' ambassadors in Washington. Hezbollah and Israel have continued

to trade blows, with hostilities focused in southern Lebanon, where Israeli forces are occupying a self-declared security zone. The U.S.-led mediation between Lebanon and Israel has emerged in parallel to diplomacy aimed at ending the U.S.-Iran conflict. Iran has said ending Israel's war in Lebanon is one of its demands for a deal over the wider conflict. Lebanon's delegation, which is attending despite objections from Shi'ite Muslim Hezbollah, has prioritized a cessation in hostilities in the talks Israel says Hezbollah must be disarmed as part of any broader peace agreement with Lebanon.



## Study Finds Childhood Junk Food Consumption Can Permanently Rewire the Brain and Impact Lifelong Health

IITM Bureau

Consuming large amounts of junk food early in life may cause lasting changes in the brain, even if a person later adopts a healthier diet. Scientists discovered that diets high in fat and sugar altered eating habits and affected brain regions responsible for controlling appetite. However, some beneficial gut bacteria and prebiotic fibres showed potential in reversing part of these effects. According to a new study from University College Cork (UCC), Children who regularly eat high-fat, high-sugar foods may experience lasting changes in the brain that continue long after their diets improve. Researchers also found that beneficial gut bacteria and prebiotic fibres could help reduce some of these long-term effects and support healthier eating behaviours later in life. Scientists at APC Microbiome, a leading research centre based at

UCC, discovered that unhealthy diets during early life can alter how the brain controls appetite and feeding. These changes persisted even after the unhealthy diet ended and body weight returned to normal. Today's children are surrounded by highly processed foods that are heavily marketed and easy to access. Sugary and fatty foods have become common at birthday parties, school events, sports activities, and even as rewards for good behaviour. Researchers say this constant exposure may shape food preferences from an early age and encourage eating habits that continue into adulthood. The study, which was published in *Nature Communications*, found that early exposure to calorie-dense, nutrient-poor foods can leave lasting effects on feeding behaviour. Researchers used a pre-clinical mouse model and found that animals exposed to a high-fat, high-sugar diet early in life showed persistent

changes in eating behaviour as adults. The team linked these behavioural effects to disruptions in the hypothalamus, a brain region responsible for regulating appetite and energy balance. The research also explored whether targeting the gut microbiome could help counter these effects. Scientists tested a beneficial bacterial strain (*Bifidobacterium longum* APC1472) along with prebiotic fibres (FOS) and galacto-oligosaccharides (GOS), naturally present in foods such as onions, garlic, leeks, asparagus and bananas, and widely available in fortified foods and prebiotic supplements). According to the findings, both approaches showed potential benefits when given throughout life. Gut Bacteria May Help Restore Healthy Eating Patterns “Our findings show that what we eat early in life really matters,” said Dr. Cristina Cuesta-Marti, first author of the study. “Early



dietary exposure may leave hidden, long-term effects on feeding behaviour that are not immediately visible through weight alone,” added Dr Cristina Cuesta-Marti. Researchers found that unhealthy diets early in life disrupted brain pathways linked to feeding behaviour, with effects continuing into adulthood. The findings suggest this could raise the risk of obesity later in life. Scientists also found that modifying the gut microbiota helped reduce these long-term effects. The probiotic strain *Bifidobacterium longum* APC1472 significantly improved feeding behaviour while causing only minor changes to the overall microbiome, suggesting a highly targeted effect. Mean-

while, the prebiotic combination (FOS+GOS) produced broader changes across the gut microbiome. The researchers emphasised that the findings highlight the importance of promoting healthy eating habits from an early age. While further studies in humans are needed, the results suggest that childhood nutrition may play a critical role in shaping lifelong eating behaviours and overall health. The study also points to the growing potential of gut microbiome-based interventions, such as probiotics and prebiotics, as tools for reducing the long-term impact of unhealthy diets. Experts believe that encouraging balanced nutrition could help lower the risk of health problems in the future.

## Prolonged Iran Conflict Raises Risk of World-wide Inflation and Economic Slowdown

*Dr. Rajnesh Kumar Pandey*



Since 28 February 2026, the United States and Israel have carried out multiple rounds of airstrikes against Iran, targeting the presidential compound, nuclear facilities, and missile bases. Iran's Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei and several senior officials were reportedly killed in the attacks. The U.S. operation aims to dismantle Iran's missile industry and nuclear infrastructure while promoting regime change in the country. In response, Iran launched a large-scale military retaliation under the code-name "True Promise-4."

The operation involved attacks on Israeli territory as well as U.S. military bases located in Qatar, the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia, and Jordan. Iran also announced the closure of the Strait of Hormuz. At the same time, members of the so-called “Axis of Resistance,” including Hezbollah in Lebanon and the Houthis in Yemen, have gradually become involved in the conflict. Civilian infrastructure in several Gulf States, including the UAE and Bahrain, has also come under attack, prompting several countries to announce the closure of their airspace. At present, the duration of the conflict between the United States, Israel, and Iran has already exceeded initial expectations. The hostilities have severely disrupted global energy supply, intensified inflationary pressures, and posed a direct shock to global shipping as well as the economies of Gulf countries. Iran currently demonstrates a considerable capacity for retaliation, suggesting that the conflict could turn into a prolonged confrontation.

The conflict has generated a dual shock to both oil and natural gas markets. On the oil side, Iran produces more than 3 million barrels per day and exports nearly 1.5 million barrels. Should its supply be disrupted, Asian buyers would be forced to turn to higher-priced alternative sources. On the natural gas side, Qatar, one of the world's leading liquefied natural gas exporters, announced on 2 March that it would suspend production following attacks on energy facilities. Qatar accounts for nearly 20 percent of global LNG exports and relies entirely on maritime transport without any alternative pipeline routes. The suspension of production has therefore intensified global concerns about potential disruptions to energy supply.

The conflict has also directly pushed up energy prices. Futures for Brent crude surged by as much as 13 percent at one point, briefly exceeding US\$82 per barrel. European natural gas benchmark prices, represented by the Title Transfer Facility gas price, surged by more than 100 percent within two days, marking the largest increase since March 2022. If the Strait of Hormuz remains closed for a long time, oil prices could rise to US\$100 per barrel or even higher. According to estimates by Capital Economics, if oil prices were to reach US\$100 per barrel, the global average inflation rate could increase by 0.6 to 0.7 percentage points. Meanwhile, Barclays notes that for every sustained increase of US\$10 per barrel in oil prices, global economic growth over the following twelve months could decline by 10 to 20 basis points. Stagflation risks have once again emerged as a tangible threat to the global economy.

### Photo of the Month



*Photo Credit: Aamya Narang, BA(JMC)*

## EDITORIAL BOARD

**Publisher:** IITM School of Mass Communication on behalf of Institute of Information Technology and Management; **Address:** D-29, Institutional Area, Janakpuri, New Delhi-110058; **Chief Patron:** Shri J. C. Sharma, Chairman, IITM and Shri Shiva Sharma, Ex-ecutive Director, IITM; **Editor-in-Chief:** Prof. (Dr.) Rachita Rana, Director, IITM; **Editor:** Dr. Nivedita Sharma, **Associate Editor:** Dr. Rajnesh Kumar Pandey & Ms. Jyoti B **Layout & Design:** Ms. Jyoti B. **Student Editorial Board:** Ananya Manchanda, Samridhi, Anjali Yadav, Kartik Chandel, Anushka Pandey. **E-mail:** iitm.unmesh@itmipu.ac.in



## India Post Revenue Climbs to ₹15,373 Crore in FY 2025-26 as Digital Transformation and Service Expansion Gain Momentum

IITM Bureau

India Post recorded a sharp rise in revenue to 15,373 crore in the financial year 2025–26, marking one of the strongest financial performances in its 170-year history, Union Minister of State for Communications Chandra Sekhar Pemmasani said on Monday (May 25, 2026). In an interview with DD India, Pemmasani said the department witnessed an unprecedented single-year revenue increase of 2,100 crore in FY26, compared to the historical annual growth trend of 200–300 crore. India Post's revenue stood at around 11,500 crore in 2016. The Minister attributed the turnaround to a dual-pronged

strategy involving top-down target setting and accountability, along with workforce engagement at the grassroots level. He also credited Union Communications Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia for introducing structural reforms and addressing operational bottlenecks within the department. India Post's parcel and logistics services registered 70 per cent growth during the year, driven by technology integration and expanded partnerships with e-commerce platforms. According to the Minister, parcel revenue, which stood at around 600 crore earlier, now has the potential to reach 10,000 crore. The department has introduced OTP-based deliveries, SMS



tracking, UPI-enabled payment systems and B2B partnerships with e-commerce companies to strengthen logistics operations. Route rationalization measures have also been implemented to improve delivery timelines. Following pilot projects, India Post launched 24-hour and 48-hour Speed Post delivery services across six metro cities, backed by public awareness campaigns. Pemmasani said logistics and parcel services

## Meta Reshapes Operations to Emerge as Global Artificial Intelligence Powerhouse

IITM Bureau

Meta Platforms has initiated a major restructuring exercise as the social media giant intensifies its focus on artificial intelligence to strengthen its position in the rapidly evolving AI industry.



According to reports published on May 24, 2026, the company last week laid off around 8,000 employees globally while reassigning another 7,000 workers to artificial intelligence-related roles, signalling a significant operational shift towards becoming an AI-first organization. The restructuring comes as Meta Platforms plans to sharply increase capital expenditure, with projected spending of up to \$135 billion on AI infrastructure, including advanced chips, data centres and talent acquisition. Founder and Chief Executive Officer Mark Zuckerberg has reportedly tasked Chief Technology Officer Andrew Bosworth with leading the transformation. Bosworth, also known as “Boz”, currently heads Reality Labs, Meta's wearables and metaverse division. Reports said Meta's leadership believes the company's next phase of growth will be driven by arti-

ficial intelligence, with a strategic focus on computing power, infrastructure and AI talent expected to shape its long-term competitiveness. Meta Platforms is among several major Silicon Valley technology firms placing AI at the centre of their business strategies. Earlier this month, Blackstone announced a joint venture with Google to establish a new AI cloud company, with Blackstone committing \$5 billion in equity investment. The proposed

venture is expected to provide data centre capacity, networking services and access to Google Cloud's Tensor Processing Units (TPUs) as part of a compute-as-a-service offering. Industry focus is increasingly shifting from chatbot-based AI systems to agentic AI, which is capable of operating autonomously and performing tasks without relying solely on user prompts. As part of its internal AI strategy, Meta has reportedly informed employees through an internal memo that it plans to introduce a tracking system on company computers and applications to monitor keystrokes and mouse activity for training AI models to automate certain functions.

## Major Relief for India's Seafood Industry as EU Includes Country in Revised Draft List for Continued Aquaculture Exports

IITM Bureau

India has received a major boost in its seafood export sector after the European Union (EU) included the country in its revised draft list for the continued export of aquaculture products to the European market beyond September 2026. The revised draft list published by EU on May 12, 2026, addresses concerns that emerged after India was omitted from the earlier Implementing Regulation (EU) 2024/2598 issued in October 2024. That regulation had excluded India from the

list of third countries authorized to export products of animal origin intended for human consumption to the EU from September 2026 onward. The latest development comes after India undertook several compliance measures in accordance with the European Commission (EC) Delegated Regulation (EU) 2023/905. The regulation requires exporting countries to ensure that animals and animal products exported to the EU are free from the use of antimicrobial medicinal products for growth promotion and anti-

microbials reserved for human treatment. According to the EC's communication, the revised list includes countries that have demonstrated compliance with EU restrictions on antimicrobial use in food-producing animals and have provided the required guarantees under EU regulations. The proposed inclusion is being seen as a significant relief for India's seafood industry, particularly for aquaculture exporters who depend heavily on the European market. Once the revised regulation is formally ad-



opted by the European Commission, Indian aquaculture exports to the EU are expected to continue uninterrupted beyond September 2026.

The EU remains one of the most important destinations for Indian seafood exports. During 2025–26, the EU emerged as India's third-largest seafood

Insurance (RPLI) online, download digital certificates instantly and receive maturity payments directly into bank accounts without visiting post offices. The Minister said postal savings accounts, which currently offer around 4 per cent interest, could see wider adoption through increased digital accessibility. The IT 2.0 system will also include facial recognition-based access, e-KYC, Aadhaar integration and cloud security compliance. India Post Payments Bank currently distributes nearly 45,000 crore annually through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT), making it one of the country's largest last-mile welfare delivery networks.

## Unified Payments Interface Accounted for Over 85% of Digital Transaction Volume in H2 2025, Says RBI

IITM Bureau

Reserve Bank of India said the Unified Payments Interface (UPI) accounted for the largest share of digital payment transaction volume at 85.5 per cent in the second half of 2025, highlighting the platform's growing dominance in India's payments ecosystem. According to the RBI's latest half-yearly Payment Systems Report published on May 19, 2026, National Electronic Funds Transfer (NEFT) and Prepaid Payment Instruments (PPIs) each accounted for 3.6 per cent of transaction volume, while Real Time Gross Settlement (RTGS) contributed just 0.1 per cent due to its role as a high-value, low-vol-



ume payment system. However, in terms of transaction value, RTGS remained the dominant platform with a 68.6 per cent share of total transaction value, followed by NEFT at 14.9 per cent and UPI at 9.5 per cent. PPIs accounted for only 0.1 per cent of the total transaction value. The report noted that the figures reflect RTGS' importance for large-value settlements, while UPI continues to drive

mass retail digital payments across the country. The RBI said NEFT maintained its relevance in India's evolving digital payments ecosystem due to its ability to process both small and large transactions with settlement within an hour. India's digital payments ecosystem has expanded rapidly over the past decade, with transaction volumes increasing 33 times and transaction values rising nearly three

annual accounts for FY26. The RBI said its gross income increased by 26.42 per cent over the previous financial year, while expenditure before risk provisions rose by 27.60 per cent. The central bank's net income before risk provisions and transfers to statutory funds stood at Rs 3,95,972.10 crore in FY26, compared to Rs 3,13,455.77 crore in FY25. In its statement, the RBI said the revised Economic Capital Framework (ECF) allows flexibility in maintaining the Contingent Risk Buffer (CRB) within a range of 4.5 per cent to 7.5 per cent of the balance sheet size. Taking into account

conditions, financial performance and risk management requirements, the RBI Board approved a transfer of Rs 1,09,379.64 crore towards the Contingent Risk Buffer for FY26, significantly higher than Rs 44,861.70 crore allocated in the previous year. The CRB has been maintained at 6.5 per cent of the RBI's balance sheet. Following these provisions, the Board approved the transfer of Rs 2, 86, 588.46 crore as surplus to the Central Government for the accounting year 2025-26. According to Union Budget estimates, the Centre expects to receive around Rs 3.16 lakh crore in dividends and surpluses from the RBI.

times between 2016 and 2025, according to the report. Over the last five years alone, transaction volumes have grown more than fourfold, while values nearly doubled, translating into a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 43 per cent in volume and 17 per cent in value. The RBI attributed the growth to rising smartphone penetration, the expansion of public digital infrastructure such as Unified Payments Interface, and increasing public trust in secure and seamless cashless transactions. The report further stated that total payment transaction volumes in India increased from 6,437 crore in 2021 to 26,819 crore in 2025.

shrimp continued to dominate India's seafood exports to the European region. The Ministry of Commerce & Industry said the development reflects growing confidence in India's regulatory systems, food safety standards and residue monitoring framework. The Department of Commerce, along with agencies such as the Marine Products Export Development Authority and the Export Inspection Council, has consistently played a key role in strengthening compliance mechanisms and promoting responsible aquaculture practices.

India has significantly strengthened its National Residue Control Programme (NRCP), post-harvest testing systems and surveillance mechanisms for banned antibiotics and pharmacologically active substances. Authorities have also intensified stakeholder awareness and training programmes to ensure adherence to international food safety standards. The Ministry said India has consistently improved systems related to veterinary medicinal products, antimicrobial residue monitoring, traceability and quality

assurance in aquaculture production and seafood processing. The inclusion in the revised EU draft list is being viewed as the outcome of sustained technical engagement and regulatory cooperation between India and the European Union. Industry stakeholders believe the move will support export growth, generate employment and boost foreign exchange earnings from the country's seafood sector. The move strengthens India's position in the global seafood market and supports future export growth.



## ICMR Unveils India's Biggest Biomedical Innovation Platform, Facilitates Transfer of 41 Healthcare Technologies to Industry

IITM Bureau

The Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) on Monday (May 25, 2026) organised “Medical Innovations Patent Mitra: Innovators-to-Industry (I2I) Connect” in New Delhi, marking India’s largest biomedical innovation and technology transfer facilitation event aimed at accelerating the commercialization of indigenous healthcare technologies. Held at the Manekshaw Centre, the event established one of India’s first structured platforms dedicated to biomedical innovation showcasing and technology transfer under the ICMR Medical Innovation Patent Mitra initiative. The

programme was inaugurated by Union Minister of State Prataprao Jadhav in the presence of Prof. Gobardhan Das, Member NITI Aayog. Addressing the gathering, Jadhav said the initiative represented a major step in connecting Indian science with industry to transform laboratory innovations into accessible healthcare technologies.

“India is moving from being a consumer of health technologies to becoming a global source of affordable and innovative health-care solutions, powered by institutions like ICMR and strong industry partnerships,” he said. Das said India possesses the scientific capability and



innovation ecosystem required to emerge as a global leader in health technologies. He noted that the Medical Innovation Patent Mitra initiative would play a key role in intellectual property protection, technology transfer and the faster adoption of indigenous innovations.

Dr. Rajiv Bahl, Director General, ICMR said the initiative reflected ICMR's com-

mitment to ensuring that cutting-edge research reaches people through strong industry partnerships and impactful technology transfer mechanisms. A major highlight of the event was the transfer of 41 public health technologies from ICMR institutes and innovators to industry partners for further development, manufacturing and commercialization. The

technologies included vaccines, diagnostics, medical devices and biomedical solutions targeting critical public health challenges. Among the transferred technologies were glycoconjugate and recombinant vaccines for typhoid and paratyphoid, along with diagnostic technologies for diseases such as Japanese Encephalitis, Tuberculosis and Mpox. In a first-of-its-kind initiative, India also witnessed the transfer of well-characterized inactivated KFD and Chandipura virus biomaterials to industry partners, aimed at strengthening vaccine manufacturing and biomedical research capabilities in the country.

## Childhood Junk Food Consumption Can Rewire the Brain for Life, New Study Reveals

IITM Bureau

Consuming large amounts of junk food early in life may cause lasting changes in the brain, even if a person later adopts a healthier diet. Scientists discovered that diets high in fat and sugar altered eating habits and affected brain regions responsible for controlling appetite. However, some beneficial gut bacteria and prebiotic fibres showed potential in reversing part of these effects. According to a new study from University College Cork (UCC) published on May 22, 2026, Children who regularly eat high-fat, high-sugar foods may experience lasting changes in the brain that continue long af-

ter their diets improve. Researchers also found that beneficial gut bacteria and prebiotic fibres could help reduce some of these long-term effects and support healthier eating behaviours later in life. Scientists at APC Microbiome, a leading research centre based at UCC, discovered that unhealthy diets during early life can alter how the brain controls appetite and feeding. These changes persisted even after the unhealthy diet ended and body weight returned to normal. Today's children are surrounded by highly processed foods that are heavily marketed and easy to access. Sugary and fatty foods have become common at birthday

parties, school events, sports activities, and even as rewards for good behaviour. Researchers used a pre-clinical mouse model and found that animals exposed to a high-fat, high-sugar diet early in life showed persistent changes in eating behaviour as adults. The team linked these behavioural effects to disruptions in the hypothalamus. Scientists also found that modifying the gut microbiota helped reduce these long-term effects. The probiotic strain *Bifidobacterium longum* APC1472 significantly improved feeding behaviour while causing only minor changes to the overall microbiome, suggesting a highly targeted effect.

## Nigeria Identifies 21 Regions at High and Moderate Risk Amid Concerns Over Potential Ebola Virus Importation

---

*IITM Bureau*

Nigerian public health authorities have identified 21 of the country's 36 states as being at high or moderate risk of Ebola importation, amid growing concerns over cross-border transmission. In a statement issued by the Nigeria Centre for Disease Control and Prevention (NCDC) on May 30, 2026 said that recent Ebola outbreaks in parts of East and Central Africa had increased the risk of the disease being imported into Nigeria, although no confirmed case has yet been recorded in the country. The NCDC classified the capital city Abuja, the southern states of Lagos, Rivers, Enugu, Akwa Ibom and Cross River, as well as the northern states of

Kano, Borno, Taraba and Adamawa, as high-risk areas because of active travel and trade routes linked to international airports and porous land borders, Xinhua news agency reported. The agency also listed Ogun, Ebonyi, Abia and Bayelsa states in the south, along with Nasarawa, Kaduna, Plateau, Niger, Jigawa, Katsina and Bauchi states in the north, as moderate-risk areas requiring enhanced surveillance and preparedness measures. Jide Idris, Director General of the NCDC, said the World Health Organisation (WHO)'s declaration of the Ebola outbreak as a "public health emergency of international concern" underscored the need for Nigeria to strengthen



preparedness efforts. He warned that Ebola symptoms closely resemble those of malaria and Lassa fever, increasing the risk of delayed detection and further transmission. With a population of more than 242 million, Nigeria is Africa's most populous country and the world's sixth most populous nation. Meanwhile, WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus said that the Ebola outbreak in Congo was "very complex", with conflict, insecurity,

ty, displacement, food shortages and community mistrust complicating efforts to contain the disease. Speaking to reporters on late Thursday at the airport upon arriving in the Congolese capital of Kinshasa, Ghebreyesus noted that he had come to show affected communities that “they are not alone” and that the WHO was there to support the response. Health authorities continue to urge vigilance, early reporting of symptoms, to prevent any potential spread.

## India Reaffirms Support for Africa Amid Ebola Outbreak, Emphasizes Health Cooperation

---

*IITM Bureau*

As Africa grapples with a deadly Ebola outbreak, India on Friday (May 29, 2026) expressed readiness to continue assisting affected countries and the Africa Centres for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) in dealing with the health emergency. Addressing a weekly media briefing in New Delhi, Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said that the medical supplies sent to the Africa CDC were handed over by the Indian High Commissioner in Uganda, Upender Singh Rawat, to its office there. "We have sent medical supplies to the Africa CDC. This was handed over by our High Commissioner in Uganda to the

CDC office there. We look forward to further helping in whatever manner we can with the countries and with the Africa CDC in dealing with this public health emergency that has happened on the continent. We will keep you updated as and when we have more developments on that account. But we have sent the first tranche of medical supplies to the Africa CDC,” Jaiswal stated. Last week India dispatched the first tranche of urgent medical supplies and protective kits to the Africa CDC. In a post on X, External Affairs Minister (EAM) S Jaishankar expressed India’s commitment to supporting Africa in responding to the emerging Ebola public health emergency.



“India dispatched the first tranche of urgent medical supplies and protective kits to the Africa CDC today. Committed to support Africa in responding to the emerging Ebola public health emergency,” EAM Jaishankar posted on X. On Wednesday, the Ethiopia-headquartered Africa CDC said in a social media said that the consignment, donated by the Government of India, was received in Uganda by its Eastern Africa Regional Coordinating Centre and to be deployed to

affected communities in eastern DR Congo. The supplies comprise essential diagnostics, therapeutics, infection prevention and control materials, and case management support, the agency said. "Africa CDC welcomes the arrival of emergency pharmaceutical supplies generously donated by the government and people of India to support the ongoing response to the Bundibugyo Ebola outbreak in the DRC," the continental public health agency said.

## World No Tobacco Day: Health Secretary launches Tobacco-Free Educational Institutions app to combat nicotine addiction

---

*IITM Bureau*

Ahead of World No Tobacco Day 2026, Union Health Secretary Punya Salila Srivastava on Friday (May 29, 2026) launched the pilot version of the Tobacco-Free Educational Institutions (ToFEI) Application and released a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for tobacco product sample collection, reinforcing the Centre's efforts to combat tobacco and nicotine addiction among youth. The initiatives were launched during a national event organised under the National Tobacco

Control Programme (NTCP) at Kartavya Bhawan in New Delhi. The ToFEI application is a digital platform aimed at strengthening the implementation and monitoring of tobacco-free guidelines across schools and colleges. The app is designed to facilitate self-assessment and reporting by educational institutions, monitor compliance with tobacco-control norms, enforce signage requirements, prohibit the sale of tobacco products within 100 yards of educational institutions and promote awareness activ-



ities among students and teachers. The pilot project will initially be implemented in Rajasthan, Meghalaya and Maharashtra to assess operational feasibility and strengthen reporting and monitoring systems before a nationwide rollout. According to the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW), the digital platform will support states, union territories, educational institutions and programme officials through standardised monitoring and compliance assessment mechanisms, thereby improving account-



Government's comprehensive strategy to counter nicotine and tobacco addiction," she said. The Health Secretary also highlighted the release of the SOP for tobacco product sample collection, stating that scientific and standardised procedures are essential for effective enforcement and regulatory action. The SOP outlines protocols for collection, handling, storage, transportation and documentation of tobacco product samples to ensure consistency and reliability in testing. She added that more than 2,000 Tobacco

Cessation Centres have been established across the country in district hospitals, medical colleges, dental colleges, AYUSH institutions and Non-Communicable Disease (NCD) clinics to support tobacco control efforts. Emphasising the growing burden of tobacco-related diseases, the Health Secretary said tobacco use significantly contributes to cancers, cardiovascular diseases, stroke, chronic respiratory illnesses and other non-communicable diseases that account for a major share of deaths and disability in

India. Joint Secretary Prabhakar highlighted India's leadership in evidence-based tobacco control policies and efforts to protect youth from emerging nicotine products, while Deputy Director General Dr. L. Swasthicharan reiterated the government's commitment to safeguarding children, adolescents and young adults from nicotine addiction.

The event featured a street play performed by school students with support from HRIDAY, highlighting the harmful effects of tobacco and nicotine addiction.



# Mission Mausam gets major boost as India launches first Sky-Cast system at IGI Airport

IITM Bureau

Union Minister of State for Science and Technology and Earth Sciences Dr. Jitendra Singh on Friday (May 29, 2026) inaugurated India's first "Sky-Cast" aviation weather monitoring system at Indira Gandhi International (IGI) Airport in New Delhi, saying the country has entered a new era of "fog-free, weather-smart aviation". Developed under the Centre's "Mission Mausam" initiative, the advanced integrated atmospheric monitoring system is designed to provide real-time weather intelligence to pilots, airlines and airport operators, helping reduce flight delays, diversions and cancellations caused by fog, turbulence and poor visibility. With the launch of SkyCast, India has become the 19th country in the world to deploy such an integrated aviation weather monitoring system, the minister said. He added that the next SkyCast facility will be established at Jewar Airport in Uttar Pradesh, followed by expansion to other airports across the country. The inauguration took place at IGI Airport in the presence of senior officials from the Ministry of Earth Sciences (MoES), India Meteorological Department (IMD), Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology (IITM), GMR and representatives from the aviation sector.



Addressing the gathering, Jitendra Singh said the system would significantly improve aviation safety and operational efficiency by delivering advance weather alerts to aircrew and pilots, even within short forecasting windows of around three hours. He said passengers could expect fewer weather-related disruptions in the

future as the system would help airlines and pilots take informed decisions regarding take-offs and landings during adverse weather conditions. The minister described SkyCast as a major milestone in India's aviation history, noting that it combines multiple atmospheric observation technologies for fog monitoring, tur-

bulence detection and high-impact weather forecasting into a single framework. The system integrates technologies such as Radar Wind Profiler, SODAR, Microwave Radiometer, Ground-based Fog Aerosol Spectrometer (GFAS) and CL61 Lidar-based Ceilometer to continuously monitor atmospheric conditions up to nearly three kilometres above the airport. According to the ministry, the Radar Wind Profiler forms the core of the system and measures wind speed, wind direction, turbulence, vertical velocity and boundary-layer dynamics, all considered critical during aircraft descent and landing operations.

## Samsung Elec Chairman apologises to customers, public amid labour tensions

IITM Bureau

Samsung Electronics Chairman Jay Y. Lee on May 16, issued a public apology to customers and the public over the ongoing wage dispute between the company and its labour union, as concerns grow over a possible strike that could have far-reaching economic consequences for South Korea and the global technology industry. In his first public comments on the issue, Lee expressed regret over the uncertainty created by the dispute and acknowledged the concerns of customers worldwide. "I sincerely apologise to customers around the world for causing anxiety and concern

due to issues within our company," he said. He further added that he "deeply bows in apology to the public" for the situation. The apology comes amid escalating tensions between Samsung Electronics management and its labour union after wage negotiations collapsed earlier this week. The breakdown in talks has increased the likelihood of a strike by union members, a move that could significantly disrupt operations at the world's largest memory chip manufacturer. Recognising the seriousness of the situation, South Korea's Labour Minister met Samsung Electronics executives on Saturday and urged

the company to actively engage in dialogue with union representatives to find a mutually acceptable solution. The government has emphasized the importance of resolving the dispute through negotiations rather than industrial action. Senior government officials, including the Prime Minister and the Finance Minister, have also voiced concerns about the potential impact of a strike. They warned that any prolonged disruption at Samsung could pose substantial risks to the country's economic growth, exports, and financial markets, affecting investor confidence and stability, both domestically and internationally.

## India's 47% of total additional data center capacity to be in Mumbai over the next five years: Report

IITM Bureau

Mumbai continues to hold the dominant position in the data center race in India, currently accounting for approximately 50 per cent of the total data center capacity in the country. The State benefits from submarine cable landing stations, a reliable power supply, robust roads, and established fiber infrastructure. The report noted that strong demand from the Banking, Financial Services, and Insurance (BFSI) sector, its status as a major telecom hub, and the absence of major natural threats solidify its position. Looking ahead, "47% of the total additional capacity over the next five years in India is likely to be situated



in Mumbai," according to a report published by Avendus Capital on May 29, 2026. The concentration of digital infrastructure remains highly consolidated, with nearly 98 per cent of the country's current installed capacity of 1,650 megawatts clustered within the top seven regional markets. Both Mumbai and Chennai are leading the data center expansion in India, capitalizing on the inherent advantage of

a dense wet cable ecosystem that offers the best global latencies. Chennai maintains its position as the second most preferred location for data centers in India due to strategic geographic benefits. The city is expected to absorb roughly 15 per cent of the upcoming incremental capacity. Its connectivity will expand further as three more international subsea cables are projected to establish landing stations in Chennai

over 2026-27, enhancing its appeal for infrastructure development. As per the report, Hyderabad is transforming into a major destination for both colocation facilities and hyperscaler self-build projects. The city is slated to receive approximately 11 per cent of the upcoming incremental capacity, supported by ongoing developments from CtrlS, Sify, and CapitaLand. Tech companies are expanding their footprints in the region, with Microsoft Azure making large commitments and Amazon Web Services expanding heavily. The overall market data indicates varied operational dynamics across the seven key cities.

## CNN files lawsuit against Perplexity alleging unlawful content distribution

IITM Bureau

CNN on Thursday (May 28, 2026) filed a lawsuit against Perplexity in New York federal court, alleging the AI search engine provider is unlawfully distributing its copyrighted content, marking the latest legal tussle between the AI firm and a news publisher. The complaint said that Perplexity unlawfully copied thousands of CNN stories, videos and images to power its products and distributes "identical or substantially similar" competing content. "You can't copyright facts," Perplexity spokesperson Jesse Dwyer said in response to the lawsuit. CNN is asking for an unspecified number of monetary damag-



es and a court order blocking Perplexity from violating its intellectual property rights. "CNN's lawsuit stands for the proposition that Perplexity, a company valued at tens of billions of dollars, should not be able to steal from entities that create the original content Perplexity exploits," the Warner Bros.-owned news company said in a statement. "By exploiting CNN's reporting in this manner, Perplexity violates the protections afforded by copyright law and un-

dermines the economic incentives that make original newsgathering possible," CNN said in the complaint. Since the launch of OpenAI's ChatGPT in 2022, news publishers and writers have worried about their content being repurposed to appear in the results of a chatbot query, sparking battles over copyright, compensation and ownership. CNN's lawsuit is one of dozens of high-stakes U.S. cases brought by copyright owners including news outlets,

authors and publishers against tech companies over alleged misuse of their work to train large language models. Anthropic was the first AI company to settle one of these cases last year, agreeing to pay \$1.5 billion to resolve a class action lawsuit from a group of authors. The CNN suit is the latest in a series of legal challenges brought against Perplexity, which uses AI to scour websites and answer users' queries, alleging the company has infringed copyrights and unlawfully scraped data to train its technology. Perplexity is also facing lawsuits from the New York Times, Reddit and Dow Jones, among others.

## Rajnath Singh inaugurates private defence manufacturing complex in Shirdi

IITM Bureau

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Saturday May 23, 2026, inaugurated a private sector defence manufacturing complex in Shirdi and flagged off India's first 300-km Universal Rocket Launching System 'Suryastra', asserting that a nation capable of manufacturing its own weaponry "writes its own destiny". The facility, developed by NIBE Limited, will focus on advanced artillery systems, missile and space technologies, rocket systems,

energetic materials, and autonomous defence platforms. Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis was also present at the event. Speaking at the inauguration ceremony, Rajnath Singh stressed that future wars would be determined more by advancements in munitions and automation than by the size of armed forces. Referring to the ongoing Russia-Ukraine conflict, tensions in West Asia, and India's Operation Sindoor, he said modern warfare increasingly depends

on cutting-edge indigenous capabilities. He emphasised that self-reliance in defence production was essential not only for national security but also for economic resilience and development. The Defence Minister added that the government was committed to transforming India into a global hub for munitions and automated systems through initiatives such as Make-in-India, Positive Indigenisation Lists, iDEX, ADITI, and the Technology Development Fund. The event also wit-

nessed the foundation stone laying for a missile complex linked to the Suryastra system, along with the unveiling of indigenous TNT Plant Technology, RDX Plant Technology, and a Renewable Bio-Energy Compressed Biogas Plant. An MoU was exchanged between NIBE Group and BlackSky for cooperation in satellite assembly. Rajnath Singh said the private sector's contribution to defence production had risen to nearly 25-30 per cent and the government aims to increase

it to 50 per cent in the coming years. The Defence Minister said the new complex would strengthen India's defence ecosystem by creating opportunities for MSMEs, ancillary industries, suppliers, and vendors, while generating employment and boosting technological skill development among the youth. Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis hailed the Centre's push for Aatmanirbhar Bharat in defence and said India's growing indigenous capabilities were enhancing both

national security and global peace efforts. Chief of Defence Staff Anil Chauhan, DRDO Chairman Samir V. Kamat, and senior defence and industry officials also attended the programme. India's defence manufacturing sector has emerged as one of the key pillars of the country's vision for strategic autonomy and economic growth. The inauguration of the advanced defence manufacturing complex in Shirdi reflects the rapid transformation taking place in India's defence ecosystem under the Aatmanir-

bhar Bharat initiative. With greater emphasis on indigenous research, innovation, and production, the country is steadily reducing its dependence on imported military equipment while developing world-class capabilities in missiles, artillery systems, space technologies, autonomous platforms, and advanced munitions. Experts believe that investments in such facilities will not only strengthen India's military preparedness but also generate employment opportunities, promote skill develop-

ment, and encourage technological innovation among the youth. The government's continued focus on initiatives such as Make-in-India, iDEX, and defence export promotion is expected to accelerate this growth further. As geopolitical uncertainties continue to shape global security dynamics, the development of indigenous defence capabilities is increasingly being viewed as a strategic necessity. The Shirdi facility is therefore expected to play a crucial role in strengthening national security.



## Odisha bags hosting rights for Asian Indoor Athletics Championships

IITM Bureau

Odisha has been awarded the hosting rights for the prestigious Asian Indoor Athletics Championships 2027, a decision taken by the Asian Athletics Council during its meeting in Hong Kong on Wednesday. The development marks another milestone for the state's growing profile in hosting major sports events. Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi termed it a "proud moment" for the country and Odisha, saying the state has further strengthened its position as a global sporting destination. The championship is

## Thailand Open 2026 Final: Antonsen Outlasts Vitidsarn in a 97-Minute Epic Match

IITM Bureau

The Thailand Open 2026 concluded on Sunday, May 17, delivering a spectacular day of world-class badminton action at the iconic Nimibutr Stadium in Bangkok. This year's edition of the BWF Super 500 tournament was marked by breathtaking upsets, grueling marathons, and brilliant displays of grit that kept fans on the edge of their seats until the final point was scored. The final showdown kicked off with a dramatic three-game battle in the Women's Doubles category. Top

## Sumit Antil Rewrites History Books Again, Sets New World Record For 7th Time

---

*IITM Bureau*

Indian para-sport legend Sumit Antil continues to create history as he broke the world record for the seventh time in his career. The veteran Javelin thrower scripted history on Wednesday (May 27) at the 8th Indian Open Para Athletics Championship at the iconic Shree Kantaveera International Stadium in Bengaluru. Antil broke a world record that he has held for the last three years since the 2023 Asian Para Games in Hangzhou, where he threw 73.29 m. The 27-year-old achieved the feat with an incredible throw of 74.82m in today's event in Bengaluru in the F64 category. This marks the seventh time that Antil has broken the world record in his career. He has been the world record holder since 2019, when he



expected to bring top athletes from across Asia to India. Odisha has ramped up its sports infrastructure and has held prestigious international hockey tournaments. It has won several medals in domestic hockey tournaments. Hockey Punjab and Hockey Association of Odisha clinched Bronze Medals at the 16th Hockey India Sub Junior National Championship 2026 held in April this year. Hockey Punjab finished on the podium in the men's category, and Hockey Association of Odisha secured third place in the women's competition. The performances underlined the consistent success both teams have enjoyed across domestic tour-



seeds Rin Iwanaga and Kie Nakanishi of Japan were heavily favored to lift the trophy, but China's unseeded pairing of Bao Lijing and Cao Zihan had other plans. The Men's Doubles final brought a historic breakthrough for Indonesia's Leo Rolly Carnando and Daniel Marthin. Facing the world-class top seeds Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty of India—against whom they previously held a 0-4 head-to-head record—the Indonesian duo put on a clinic. Leo and Daniel dominated the opening game, executing steep jump smashes and sharp net play to race away to a 21-12 win. The



registered a throw of 61.32 m in the World Para Athletics Grand Prix in Italy. Later, he set the world record three times while winning the gold medal at the Tokyo Paralympics in 2021 with throws of 66.95 m, 66.08 m, and 62.88 m. Later that year, he again broke the world record with a throw of 68.62m at the Indian Open. Since the last time he set the world record in Hangzhou, Antil won the gold medal for the second time in the Paralympics in 2024 at Paris with a throw of 70.59 m. He has won the gold at the World Championships thrice by standing on top of the podium in 2023 (Paris), 2024 (Kobe), and 2025 (New Delhi). It is worth noting that the world record Antil set today is dependent on the throw being ratified by World Para Athletics. Antil's next objective will be to defend his crown at the Asian Para Games, which will take place in Aichi Prefecture and Nagoya in Japan from 18th to 24th October. As he prepares for the Asian Para Games later this year, Antil's remarkable achievement serves as a testament to his consistency, resilience, and relentless pursuit of excellence.

naments over the years through sustained podium finishes and a steady production of international-level players. Hockey Punjab have been one of the most consistent performers in domestic competitions, securing 33 Medals (14 Gold, 6 Silver, 13 Bronze) across categories. Hockey Association of Odisha have also built a well-balanced ecosystem across both men's and women's categories, securing 26 Medals (11 Gold, 7 Silver, 8 Bronze). The men's teams have contributed 19 Medals (10 Gold, 6 Silver, 3 Bronze), led by exceptional performanc-

second game turned into an absolute epic, with the Indians saving four consecutive championship points to force an intense extra-point extension. Amid a raucous Bangkok crowd, the Indonesians showed immense composure to close out the match 25-23, securing a memorable emotional victory—particularly for Daniel Marthin, who had recently returned to elite competition following a lengthy one-year injury layoff. The Japanese duo initially took control by winning a tight first game 21-19. However, Bao

## Aravindh becomes first Indian

IITM Bureau

Indian Grandmaster Aravindh Chithambaram has secured qualification for the chess main event at the Esports World Cup 2026 after winning the Road to EWC qualifier at DreamHack Atlanta. The victory also confirmed S8UL Esports's entry into its third title at the tournament. Aravindh became the first Indian player to officially qualify for the Esports World Cup chess event after coming through a challenging format featuring rapid games and Armageddon tiebreakers. The qualifier included a double-elimination group stage followed by playoffs, with all matches played at a 10-minute time control without increment. The 26-year-old advanced from Group B with wins over Kyler Raines, Justin Liang, Oleksander Bortnyk

es in Junior and Sub Junior competitions. On the women's side, Hockey Association of Odisha have secured 7 Medals (1 Gold, 1 Silver, 5 Bronze), with the Junior Women's team contributing one Bronze medal, while the Sub Junior Women's team have secured one Silver and four Bronze Medals, highlighting a steady and growing pipeline in the ranks. Hockey Association of Odisha's strength is rooted in its strong grassroots culture, supported by academies, great infrastructure and coaching systems that have created a solid foundation for young players.

and Cao bounced back with relentless tactical adjustments, capturing the second game 21-16. In the high-stakes decider, the Chinese pair held their nerve during the critical closing rallies, sealing the victory 21-19 in a marathon encounter lasting 1 hour and 12 minutes to secure an unexpected title. The tournament wrapped up with the Mixed Doubles final, pitting Denmark's experienced second seeds Mathias Christiansen and Alexandra Boje against China's rising prospects Zhu Yijun and Li Qian.

and Christopher Woo before edging past Woo 2-1 in the upper bracket semifinals. He later defeated Alexey Sarana by the same margin to book a place in the grand final. Sarana initially took control of the final by winning the opening two games from the lower bracket side. Aravindh, however, fought back under pressure and sealed the contest in the Armageddon decider to clinch the title. The win earned Aravindh USD 15,000 in prize money and a spot among the eight players already confirmed for the Esports World Cup chess main event, scheduled from August 11 to 15. The tournament will feature a prize pool of USD 1.5 million. With the qualification, S8UL has now secured places in three Esports World Cup titles after previously qualifying in Fortnite and Honor of Kings.

## BCCI Announces India Test, ODI Squad For Afghanistan Series: No Bumrah! - Check Squad

IITM Bureau

The Board of Control for Cricket in India has officially finalized the national squads for the upcoming one-off Test match and subsequent three-match One Day International series against Afghanistan. Following an intense selection committee meeting headed by the national panel, the governing hierarchy has established a calculated squad matrix aimed at addressing immediate fitness and workload concerns. The senior leadership group has prioritized traditional format stability for the solitary Test match, scheduled to commence in Mullanpur from June 6, immediately following the conclusion of domestic franchise commitments. The specialist red-ball combination features an emphasis on tackling spin-friendly regional conditions, a tactical vulnerability that heavily hindered the collective performance of the top-order framework during previous home cycles. Confirmed India Test Squad: Shubman Gill (c), Yashasvi Jaiswal, KL Rahul (VC), Sai Sudharsan, Rishabh Pant, Devdutt Padikkal, Nitish Kumar Reddy, Washing-



ton Sundar, Kuldeep Yadav, Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna, Manav Suthar, Dhruv Jurel. The selection panel has constructed a highly versatile white-ball contingent for the three-match ODI itinerary, with fixtures strategically mapped across Dharamsala, Lucknow, and Chennai starting on June 14. The selected resource pool reflects a distinct emphasis on athletic durability, ensuring that all chosen participants are physically prepared to manage the exhaustive demands of a full one-hundred-over international fixture. Confirmed India ODI Squad: Shubman Gill, Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli, Shreyas Iyer, Ishan Kishan, Hardik Pandya, Nitish Kumar Reddy, Washington Sundar, Kuldeep Yadav, Arshdeep Singh, Prasidh Krishna, Prince Yadav, Gurnoor Brar. The primary internal debates ahead of the official announcement centered on managing the physical out-

put of elite pace assets alongside validating the recovery timelines of senior international batsmen. Furthermore, the integration of breakout domestic performers from the recent first-class and T20 tournament cycles indicates a clear desire to expand the immediate international depth chart. With a blend of experienced campaigners and emerging talents, India will look to make a strong statement against Afghanistan in both formats. The series provides an important opportunity for the team management to assess squad depth, fine-tune combinations, and build momentum ahead of a packed international calendar. Cricket fans will also be keen to see how the younger players adapt to the demands of international cricket on the big stage. The performances in this series could also play a crucial role in shaping India's plans for upcoming major ICC tournaments.

## to qualify for Esports World Cup chess event



Fellow Indian Grandmasters Nihal Sarin and Pranesh M are also still in contention for qualification through other pathways. S8UL CEO Animesh Agarwal said Aravindh's qualification was a major moment for Indian chess and reflected the organisation's focus on creating opportunities for Indian talent at international events. The Esports World Cup 2026 will be held from July 6 to August 23 and is expected to feature more than 2,000 players from over 100 countries competing across multiple titles. Aravindh has been

consistent performers on the international chess circuit in recent years. Earlier in 2025, he captured the prestigious Prague Masters title, defeating several elite Grandmasters and further enhancing his reputation as one of India's rising stars. His qualification for the Esports World Cup adds another milestone to an impressive career that has seen him steadily climb the global rankings. The inclusion of chess in the Esports World Cup has brought together the traditional mind sport and the rapidly growing esports ecosystem, attracting some of the

world's strongest players and expanding the game's reach among younger audiences. With top Grandmasters from across the globe expected to compete, the tournament is set to be one of the most competitive chess events of the year. As the countdown to the Esports World Cup begins, Aravindh's qualification marks a significant achievement for Indian chess, highlighting the country's growing influence on the global stage and raising hopes for a strong Indian presence in one of the biggest esports and chess spectacles of the year. With his recent form and growing confidence, the Indian Grandmaster will be aiming to make a deep run in the tournament and compete for the coveted world title. The victory adds another landmark achievement to his career.